Trump Plans to Close and Rebuild a Public Golf Course in Washington

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President Donald Trump has announced plans to **renovate** East Potomac Golf Links, a public golf course in Washington, D.C., about 2 miles south of the White House. The course sits on national park land.

In a post on Truth Social on Sunday, Trump called the current course "old, broken, **dilapidated**, and of no further use or effect." He said work will begin on November 15 and the course will close for about 15 months. He shared a plan for a new course he said would be able to host world-class tournaments.

The course has been at the center of a court case for months. In February, a Washington **preservation** group and two people sued the U.S. Department of the Interior and the National Park Service. They argued that a "championship-style golf course" would raise the cost of playing at a facility that was meant to be "open to all people."

The government argues that the people suing have not shown they were actually harmed. Its lawyers said the **plaintiffs**' wish for the park service to match their "aesthetic and recreational preferences" is not a **legally protected interest**.

The federal judge in the case, Ana C. Reyes, ordered the administration to stop cutting down trees at the park. On Friday, the government asked for Reyes to be removed from the case, accusing her of **bias**. Trump's post did not mention the legal fight.

Skye Perryman, who leads Democracy Forward, a group representing the people suing, said the park "is meant for everyone to enjoy." NPR asked the Interior Department and the White House for comment but had not heard back.

The next court hearing is scheduled for Monday. The golf course is one of several changes Trump is seeking in Washington, including a 250-foot arch near the National Mall.

Word Treasure

renovate -- To renovate means to repair and update a building or place so it is like new.

dilapidated -- Dilapidated describes something old and falling apart from neglect.

preservation -- Preservation means protecting something, like a historic place, so it is not damaged or changed.

plaintiffs -- Plaintiffs are the people or groups who bring a lawsuit to court.

legally protected interest -- A legally protected interest is a right or concern that the law allows a person to defend in court.

bias -- Bias means unfairly favoring one side over another.

Background you need

The National Park Service, part of the Department of the Interior, manages national park land across the country, including parks in Washington, D.C.

East Potomac Golf Links is a public course on that park land, which means anyone can pay to play there rather than only club members.

When people believe a government plan breaks the law or harms them, they can sue, and a federal judge decides whether the plan can continue.

A judge can order a pause, like stopping tree cutting, while the court case is still being decided.

Break it down

LEAD: Trump announces a renovation that will close a public D.C. golf course for about 15 months

KEY EVENT: Sunday Truth Social post with a plan for a world-class course

+- WHO: President Trump, the Interior Department and National Park Service, preservation group plaintiffs, Judge Ana C. Reyes

+- WHERE: East Potomac Golf Links on national park land in Washington, D.C.

+- WHEN: work to begin November 15; next hearing Monday

CONFLICT: lawsuit says the course was meant to be open to all; government says no real harm shown

EVIDENCE: judge ordered tree cutting stopped; government asked to remove the judge for bias

CONTEXT: one of several changes Trump seeks in Washington, including a 250-foot arch

OPEN QUESTION: Will the court allow the renovation to go ahead?

Why it matters

The case tests who gets to decide how public park land in the nation's capital is used, and whether it stays affordable for everyone. It also shows how courts can check government plans.

Test what you remember

1. Where is East Potomac Golf Links?

- (A) In Florida near a beach
- (B) In Washington, D.C., about 2 miles south of the White House
- (C) Next to the U.S. Capitol in Virginia
- (D) Inside a private club in New York

2. How long did Trump say the course would be closed?

- (A) Five years
- (B) One summer
- (C) About 15 months
- (D) Two weeks

3. What do the people suing worry a championship-style course would do?

- (A) Bring too many tourists
- (B) Flood the park
- (C) Close the White House
- (D) Raise the cost of playing at a course meant to be open to all

4. What did Judge Ana C. Reyes order the administration to do?

- (A) Pay a fine
- (B) Stop cutting down trees at the park
- (C) Open the course at night
- (D) Finish the course quickly

5. What did the government ask for on Friday?

- (A) A new golf tournament
- (B) More money for the course
- (C) An end to the lawsuit by agreement
- (D) For Judge Reyes to be removed from the case

6. When is the next court hearing?

- (A) Monday
- (B) Next February
- (C) No hearing is planned
- (D) November 15

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. President Trump: He calls the current course old, broken and of no further use and wants a course able to host world-class tournaments.

2. Preservation group and plaintiffs: They argue a championship-style course would raise costs at a facility meant to be open to all people.

3. Interior Department and National Park Service: They argue the plaintiffs have not shown actual harm and that their preferences are not a legally protected interest.

4. Democracy Forward: Its leader, Skye Perryman, says the park is meant for everyone to enjoy.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):